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The End of Enlightenment: A Reply to My Critics

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I

I am grateful – that is an understatement – to all the contributors to this review symposium. I also want to thank Robin Mills for doing the substantial practical work behind the scenes. Having one's work scrutinised is always a privilege, whether the judgements are positive or negative. And I feel that overall, I've got away relatively lightly given the far-greater expertise of the contributors in so many fields of eighteenth-century history and thought. I want to highlight a comment in Bowman's and de Felipe's response, as they capture what I was trying to do in writing *The End of Enlightenment*, because one of the goals was to move away from direct parallels and genealogies towards actors in time seeing themselves to have failed in their politics and having to readjust their goals, and more rarely their overall beliefs or intentions:

In the *End of Enlightenment* readers are treated to a discussion of various figures responding to the world as it happened, as opposed to them being extracted from their time and associated with a particular political ideology. Whatmore's text, it seems, aims to nuance our contemporary caricatured views of what was a rather complex period, marked by an eclectic, at times almost incongruent set of intellectual approaches and structures developed by individuals ultimately motivated by a desire to take an active role in the formulation of a 'new future' aided by technological developments and trade expansion. The result is somewhat destabilizing; the figures discussed become harder to characterize, more idiosyncratic, and seemingly more pragmatic in their outlook.

One of the points I wanted to make was that turns that we might today describe as towards the left or towards the right were taken in the final decades of the eighteenth century by actors in response to crisis, and that in crisis times someone who might see themselves as an advocate of peace, toleration and the rule of rights was likely portrayed as fanatic by their opponents, and might end up *being* fanatic in practice as they blamed particular groups, parties or individuals for the failure of their political visions.

Jacques-Pierre Brissot or Thomas Paine variously called themselves friends of mankind, the ultimate signifier of cosmopolitanism, whereas in practice they justified eliminating their opponents, in Brissot's case, and international war, the expansion of empire and domestic coups in Paine's. James Mackintosh, having become a convert to Edmund Burke's view of the French Revolution, continued to reject Burke's advocacy of the arming of the autocratic states by British funds, which Mackintosh considered subsidies to tyranny. France was attempting, after all, to become a free state; Mackintosh hated the idea of free states fighting each other in a world largely dominated by despots and autocrats. This is not to judge them, because that is not what historians do; it is to better explain what they were doing, the consequences of their reform proposals in attempting to realise them, and the nature of their political thought as it played out in practice, against the background of a world changing at high speed. Identities proved singularly flexible as contexts altered, and this is one of the fundamental characteristics of the era.

In what follows I engage with the criticisms of the argument of the book. Many of these I agree with. What I will be concerned with is the drawing out of some of the arguments of *The End of Enlightenment* that were implicit rather than explicit, while clarifying others where possible.

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II

Let me start with Richard Bourke's characteristically insightful criticism of two arguments. The first is that the fanaticism unleashed during the revolutionary era was something new. As Bourke puts it:

... [it is] arguable that post-Revolutionary fanaticism is an altogether discrete entity, poorly understood by assimilating it to forms of religious sensibility. According to Hegel, the style of revolutionary consciousness on display in France in the late eighteenth century was an expression of modern moral attitudes rooted in conceptions of the autonomous will. For him, this disposition should not be confused with the mindset exemplified by Anabaptism, Puritanism and the Covenanting tradition. If Hegel is right, then the point about the culture of Revolutionary rights, and related ideas of conscientious dissent, is that they represent a departure from strictly Christian tenets of belief.

Bourke and Hegel are right. There was something different about French revolutionary fanaticism and by implication the world thereafter was different. But in order to make my argument clearer I need to explain some of the intellectual debts behind *The End of Enlightenment*, which may be obvious while their implications are not.

Many of the contributors noted my debt to John Pocock. I relied heavily on Pocock's notion of what he termed 'the enlightened narrative', justifying the optimistic period of relative peace and toleration in conditions of a successful balance of power after the treaties of Utrecht.¹ Rather than being an outlier, as Conor Bollins says, my enlightenment is Pocock's, seeing enthusiasm as an anti-self. Pocock was of the view that his Utrecht system of peace, with all the optimism about progress and commerce, was defended by scholars like Nick Phillipson and John Robertson.

The shattering of peace, especially after the Seven Year's War, put an end to enlightenment as Pocock defined it and different species of fanaticism began to abound, the nature and variety of which depended on who was observing the shift; but everyone agreed a shift had occurred, the world had changed, and older confidences no longer held fast or could be relied upon. Pocock argued in his *Barbarism and Religion* volumes that the threat of universal monarchy was largely vanquished by the Utrecht enlightenment and that developments in China and in Russia put an end to the possibility of the invasion of eastern Europe from steppe nomads. The collapse of Rome by luxury, ambitious generals wielding powerful legions devoted to them, or the decline of a moral framework underpinning free-state survival, remained nightmares in liberty-loving European imaginations. As free states disappeared across the continent, the most peculiar of free states, Britain, survived. This was the great shock of the century.

III

The other major influences that need to be acknowledged are István Hont and Michael Sonenscher. Each of them has emphasised that war was the driver of eighteenth-century politics, far more than commerce or commercial society (both reject the term capitalism as over-general and imprecise).² I will focus on Hont. Hont was famously unhappy with the teaching of political thought and the inherited canon, which he worried resulted in sloppy research, when the clichés of teaching were replicated. One technique Hont felt worked was to question traditionally established genealogies. He thought that individuals facing political and economic problems would naturally draw upon a variety of texts to help them, and that in so doing they would reinterpret each historic author, sensibly or fantastically, as they saw fit. Perpetual reinterpretation was the fate of every text fortunate enough to be used by subsequent interlocutors. Pocock's depiction of tunnel traditions, entailing a commitment by authors to republicanism, natural law or Protestant theology, for example, was complicated by ceaseless criss-crossing between traditions, creating intellectual lattices. Hont thought that comparisons between authors deemed traditionally to be from different traditions, such as Rousseau and Smith, yielded more complex but also more revealing and useful perspectives on the past.

At the same time, there were fundamental divisions in attitudes to politics. One was the perspective upon sociability. Hont wanted to highlight a major genealogy that he felt derived from Hobbes's

De Cive, expressing the fear that natural social relationships, established outside of politics and potentially prior to the creation of a state, could be drawn upon to justify utopian schemes for social transformation. Natural, pacific and harmonious states of nature could be imagined in law, theology, politics and economics. Hobbes thought such schemes had origins in ancient philosophical traditions, but also in Christian history. They were dangerous because they could justify revolution, war and the collapse of polities. There was no prior creation of a social order in the state of nature or via non-state institutions such as markets, via the impulses of natural sociability, or other means of presuming the existence of a religious or a secular overlapping consensus.³ According to Hont, a genealogy of fanaticism was delineated by Hobbes, and it was followed by those who shared his anti-utopian and cynical stance upon the capacities and limits of political action, including Smith, Rousseau and Kant.

The Rawlsian idea of an overlapping consensus mattered to Hont. John Rawls had developed it as a strategy to establish agreement between humans, who put aside their national identity, class and other particular attributes the better to establish a harmonious and free society. The popularity of Rawls' idea of an overlapping consensus indicated that utopian schemes for social harmony were ubiquitous in the contemporary social sciences and especially in political theory. Hont was of the view that such a presumption of agreement, divorced from an identification with particular polity or time, and derived from generalisations about human political action rather than specific conditions, including crisis conditions, ultimately emerged from an anti-Hobbesian cosmopolitan and utopian heritage, the politics of mankind, which had been a major cause of the French Revolution.⁴ And the French Revolution, for Hont, was the great disaster of modern times, the progenitor of egalitarian schemes of social transformation which resulted in civil war and tyranny. Rawls was, for Hont, a latter-day revolutionary, inadvertently fostering his own species of fanaticism in the form of politics divorced from reality.

Hont waged a battle against the ongoing influence of the French Revolution in political thought, arguing that attempts to replay the revolution without Terror, the rise of an imperialist First French Republic or First French Empire, without Bonaparte and tyranny, was an ongoing tragedy of modern political thought and perpetually doomed to failure. Hont rejected utopian, over-general and ultimately apolitical theorising. He considered it to be fanatic. He could not understand, for example, how scholars could discuss the functioning of a republic or justify republicanism without reference to the functions of the economy, public-debt financing, or the security dilemmas of international relations. Political thought in a profound sense for Hont had declined since Hume, for whom the idea of discussing politics in a laboratory divorced from reality meant not actually discussing politics at all.

Hont saw himself in part to be following Reinhardt Koselleck against Frankfurt School and neo-Marxist utopianisms, evinced by such scholars as Seyla Benhabib and Axel Honneth on the left and Rawls and neo-Kantians on the right.⁵ Hont once made the point that he had been invited to teach Honneth's students in Jena and discovered that they were of the view that political thought began with Hegel; those who disagreed with such a view were certain that political thought started in fact with Kant. Hont found such approaches to be ridiculous, because for him German thought, however defined, remained within the confines of the eighteenth-century crises every state continued to face, the rise of commercial society in conditions of reason of state, the tendency of commercial societies to fight wars for trade, the reliance of states upon national debts necessary to pay for expensive military technology, and the urban-rural divide which brought increasing numbers seeking work into growing towns and cities. This was the stuff of politics. The fundamental divide, for Hont, was between those who believed humans could live in union with each other because of a shared moral commitment, whether religious or secular in origin, and those who adhered to Hobbes's darker view of human nature as anti-social, anti-competitive and ultimately wicked, bending towards aggression with malice. For the latter, social structures underpinned by the political authority of the state needed to be erected to prevent humans from destroying one another. But the international system was a different challenge altogether.⁶

Hont thought that modern states would do well to develop new histories of crisis and fanaticism. He called Samuel Pufendorf the first socialist for positing a negative community as the origin of mankind, envisaging society to have emerged before the state.⁷ According to Hont there was a tradition of social science, entirely misunderstood historically, facilitating some of the most imaginative reform strategies for eighteenth-century polities in the new worlds of commerce, war and debt that they found themselves in. But the fundamental question was the politics consequent upon such visions, and whether they could be trusted to avoid civil war, international war, domestic tyranny and cultures of fanaticism. The point Hont made regularly was that it does not matter how much progress has been made regarding wealth or peace because at some point they will be recognised to be fleeting. Turbulence is a fact of politics in commercial societies engaged in international trade, and dependent upon financial markets to generate funds for self-defence; political thought can help most when nation states face crisis. The lack of a focus upon crisis politics was one of his criticisms of the Cambridge School (there were others, as Bourke well knows).

The purpose of this digression is to respond to Bourke's point about post-revolutionary fanaticism. To contemporary observers it looked as if the French Revolution had repeated the history of Protestant churches, creating new sacred republics that divided and battled one another, before another new republic/church emerged. And then Bonaparte replicated the history of Rome's republic. But commentators were aware – and Burke was the great sage in this respect – that the revolutionary commitment to die for the republic, generalised to encompass an entire people in arms, amounted to an altogether new species of secular nationalism/fanaticism, which Burke thought had to be fought to the death even at the cost of the ruin and bankruptcy of Britain. A war was being fought for civilisation against barbarism.

Hegel did not see the world in Burkean terms, we know from Bourke's *Hegel's World Revolutions*.⁸ Yet he was aware that the free states of republican France and contemporary Britain could both be charged with being fanatic entities while contributing understandably to the development of the idea of liberty. Neither were model polities to be embraced from Berlin. And Hegel knew precisely that he was living in conditions of international war, nationalism, commerce as reason-of-state and the jealousy of trade. Hont called him a socialist too, in a direct line following on from Pufendorf.

IV

Bourke's second argument, which is also made by Jessica Patterson, is that while my rejection of linear progress since the eighteenth century is explicable, the implied argument that there was 'a seismic rupture followed by a sustained downturn' is unconvincing. Rather than a terminal 'end of enlightenment', there was an ongoing attempt to restore peace and toleration. I think that this is right. For many Britons, for instance, by the 1850s a thoroughly successful pax Britannica founded on a global and imperial economy that was not a mercantile system had restored enlightenment. For critics, the opium wars and famine in Ireland and India showed Britain's eighteenth-century self-mirroring past and present; neo-Machiavellian political economy remained the driving force of this so-called free state, which was in fact a pirate polity.

The reason for using the term 'end of enlightenment' was because I don't think we have managed to restore the optimism of Pocock's utopian enlightenment/enlightened narrative. It appeared to have returned in technicolour at the end of the nineteenth century, when every other book was about progress and the rational and beneficial dominion of Western civilisation. The events of the twentieth century destroyed such perspectives. Post-1945 we did indeed see the restoration of forms of enlightenment that some thought would last until the 'end of history and the last man'. But we have all too quickly returned to the normal in our modernity, a time when what exists cannot be expected to remain and when we need to brace ourselves for potentially radical change in politics, economy and society.

In the present many argue that we are reliving the experience of the 1930s. The more informative parallel is the 1790s. Enlightenment then was not entirely defeated; but it did end, despite the rise of the free states, presaging the era of democratic dominion, which Tocqueville foresaw in the 1830s. It has not come back. My terminology is intended to highlight contrasts that need to be drawn if we want to understand our own time, still rooted in the end of enlightenment crisis.

Bourke emphasises, following figures such as Steven Pinker, the progress regarding equality and wealth that have been made. And free states, which Bourke defines as popular sovereignty, governmental accountability, the rule of law and fear of over-powerful figures, remain the dominant form of state. As he summarises his view:

None of these accomplishments are without their fragilities, but in spite of that they remain effective norms in the modern world. Toleration is a moral goal that is constantly in danger, but it has yet to be rejected as a standard for behaviour. There has likewise been no drastic regress in intellectual culture. Science enjoys rational precedent over religion, and philosophy is authoritative over prophecy. In tracing developments since the eighteenth century, we are obliged to follow an ambiguous, erratic and complex course. But it is hard to see that Enlightenment has failed.

The point has been made that enlightenment did fail and we have not returned to a world in which fanaticism has been in abeyance, partly because of the force of jealousy of trade, public-funded war, and hyper-nationalist, cosmopolitan, religious or republican ideologies for true social union, which regularly return, like the heads of the Lernean Hydra, renewing themselves when severed.

We remain mired in eighteenth-century problems that we have never managed to overcome. Alexander Herzen, in *From the Other Shore*, used the image of a pregnant widow to describe the situation in Europe after the 1848 Revolutions.⁹ The old world had departed; a new one was yet to be born. On a global canvass and for different reasons, this was also Hont's opinion. He identified in 1990 the essential problem since the eighteenth century, that there was 'enough commercial sociability in modern society to make the politics of virtue impossible, but not enough to keep the peace.'¹⁰ The irony of the rise and dominion of the kinds of state that Bourke praises is that they have been accompanied by accusations of atrocity and imperialism and now environmental degradation, all of which can be traced to historic justifications of what needs to be done to ensure the survival of the nation state.

The additional assertion is that a further transformation of the world took place in the twentieth century that is less commented upon than the Cold War, decolonisation, the rise in living standards or technological progress. It is the collapse of Britain as a free state. The dominion of free states, the truly shocking and surprising outcome of the end of enlightenment, inexplicable to most eighteenth-century minds, was itself fragile. Britain's economic collapse after two world wars and its own loss of empire, meant that the world shifted to an era of the protection of free states by another power, the United States, which was both different to Britain and keen to ensure the relative weakness of comparable free states, including all of those of Europe. Continuing the association of free states with fragility/rapid rises and falls, we may be at the end of U.S. dominion and entering a period where a greater diversity of states, all claiming to be free in different ways, seek to fill the gap.

I am not an opponent of progress, especially equality, but most egalitarian reform strategies historically have had to suffer the outbreak of social conflict, sometimes civil and international war, and also backlashes, as victims are redefined as privileged and the newly elevated are assaulted by new groups calling foul, identifying themselves as the true victims of modern society. These processes have been commonplace since the creation of free states, but it is the latter in modern conditions that merit further analysis.

I don't think we get the history of free states right. One of the things we need to do is distinguish between British liberalisms and North American variants. It was one of the points obvious to Fritz Hayek between the 1930s and 1950s. Hayek had experienced the death of liberty when young, he was sure, in the Austro-Hungarian Empire, which he thought to date had done a good job of solving the nationalities question. Despite fighting for Austro-Hungary during the First World War, he

converted to the view that he ought to have supported the enemy he had been willing to die battling, Britain, because it was the freest polity in human history. Hayek had no faith in the dominion of the United States as a free state and was pessimistic for the future in part because of the relative collapse of Britain. That event, the consequences of which he felt were being ignored by economists, philosophers and political theorists, represented a disaster for the prospects of civilisation.

V

Patterson's second major criticism, beyond my admittedly opaque parallels between past and present, is that I lump together Marxists, critical theorists and advocates of post-colonial studies. She is right. I blame Hont, who was similarly a lumper when it came to the exponents of the union of humanity, unions of the workers or the oppressed of different races or creeds. Hont had no time for Habermas when writing about the eighteenth century or the present. He thought all Frankfurt schoolers to be failed exponents of late enlightenment cosmopolitanism, the bankruptcy of which had been proven in the hypocrisy of the French Revolution, when advocates of rights justified every crime conceivable on the grounds of the necessity of maintaining the union of the devotedly virtuous and dedicatedly republican, if the republicanism being espoused was of the right stripe.

Hont, of course, lived in a Marxist regime for the first decades of his life. He joined the communist party and had to act out the identification of bourgeois deviationism. He experienced the rewriting of history as fantasy, the pollution of historical scholarship by the distorted morals of the ideologically fanatic, and the consequences for deviants and dissenters. His own family included devout socialists for whom antisemitism or sexism could not exist under the Soviet Union; the state had abolished social problems. For Hont, a grisly tyranny was being defended as an egalitarian utopian.

And for Hont, if you speculate about political reform then you need to have concrete examples in mind. One problem he had with Marxists was the lack of a successful example of a flourishing state that could be looked upon as a model. The problem I have with some examples of post-colonial or subaltern studies is they rest on the presumption of the superiority of the nation state as an independent sovereign entity in a world of similarly independent nation states. This has not mapped onto reality since the eighteenth century, because of the jealousy of trade, the turn to empire caused by the need to pay for military technology by taxing trade, and the desire for states, whether newly independent or not, to expand their borders or markets by whatever measures are open to them.

The pretence that we live in a decolonising world does us no good because most states continue to seek by every means available to turn themselves into empires and to venerate the empires they imagine themselves once to have been. True post-colonial studies has to abolish empire or think of ways to mitigate the jealousy of trade, which was attempted in the eighteenth century, as I outline in *The End of Enlightenment* and examined in more detail in *Against War and Empire*. But the attempt was a failure and has continued to fail ever since. I don't see a major difference between the behaviour of present-day China, Russia, Brazil or India and the British regarding the jealousy of trade.

We have not emerged into a post-imperial utopia, however much we bash the Europeans of the past and the genuine crimes that accompanied their imperial endeavours. I am more interested in distinguishing between species of empire, especially the frontier empires of modernity, including Britain, the United States and Russia, and the anti-colonial, resource-poor movements which sought to smash these empires, and replace them with their own frontier-expanding polities, such as Germany and Japan.

We can learn a lot from pan Africanism in the twentieth century and the attempts by remarkable scholars such as C. L. R. James to develop states that were capable of standing toe-to-toe militarily against the Western powers that had taken control of Africa and cut it up into garbled approximations of nations. But it is the case, as C. L. R. James lamented time after time, that in so many of the independence movements liberty was transient once the colonial powers had departed. Zimbabwe was a classic case. The freedom rhetoric promised a unified state from which racism would

be banished and native Africans would enjoy liberty for the first time since the invasion of the Europeans. In practice, Joshua Nkomo's party mapped onto his own Ndebele tribe, the leaders of which were trained by the Soviets, and the alliance with Robert Mugabe's Shona people, educated by Maoist cadres, proved superficial.

The Maoists, being trained to live with the peasants like fish in water, were much more likely to win popular elections and duly did so, bringing Mugabe to power.¹¹ Mugabe quickly used Ian Smith's oppressive military against the Ndebele, inaugurating a tyranny that was both predictable and long-lasting. No union, utopia or innocent post-colonialism here. When Mugabe was finally challenged in 2017, one observer commented, 'new crocodile, same teeth.'¹² The verdict could be projected backwards historically.

Because of this approach, I see neo-Marxist historiographies facing exactly the same problem as their forbears, outside the small circle who thought or think Stalin or Mao or Castro or Mugabe to be genuine freedom fighters, which is that the forms of union called for by the exercise of socialist or communist virtue, when translated into political imperatives, go through exactly the same process as radical Protestants or Christian evangelicals everywhere, or other founders of new churches, religions, cults or sects; this is the need to crush dissent, to unite the social body by the sacred veneration of a leader, or unite all parties by the blaming of, hatred of, or willingness to exterminate the deviant or different 'other', always blamed for the failure of the church, the revolution or social movement. We see this process regularly operating in the Culture Wars too, and again in the backlash against them. Hont would say that Hobbes foresaw all of this in his descriptions of democratic gentlemen and fanatic clergy in *Behemoth*, whose ideas were a fundamental driver of the civil wars.¹³

Civil war, as David Armitage explains, is a particular curse of the present and a real prospect in free states, as dangerous as the rise of the tyrants for whom it rolls out the red carpet.¹⁴ It may, of course, be possible to establish perpetually non-fanatic churches, republics that avoid civil war and Caesars, and socialist societies that are egalitarian, pacific and libertarian. But I am not interested in such prospects because I cannot yet identify them. It has never made sense to me to extract the 'good' parts of the French Revolution from the bad or argue that Britain's mercantile empire was a 'bad' element of a positive whole. The great facts of the eighteenth century were the survival of Britain as a free state and its rise to military supremacy, which had not been the case for a free state since Rome, and the absolute failure of the socially levelling experiment of the French Revolution. The most significant events of the twentieth century were the collapse of two purportedly free states, both empires, the Soviet Union and the British Empire. The failure of the former signified the bankruptcy of Marxism, except its Maoist variant, which has enjoyed an alternative history.

According to Hont, to return to him again, there was little that was new in modern history. The likelihood of cyclical descents from popular revolution and rebellion, either democratic or via armed mobs, into the rule of strongmen promising the restoration of order, national greatness or a glorious new society, supported by troops from the unemployed of the cities, had been predicted as long ago as James Harrington. But Hont felt that scholarship was limited when dealing with such issues, failing to link politics to the economy, with dangerous consequences because of the significance of the movement from the countryside into the towns that characterised every commercial society.

VI

Iain McDaniel does an excellent job of summarising some of the responses across Germany to the rise of Britain. And naturally enough, it is not the case that the British are a model for everyone. Far from it. They are a model for some who had either created or aspired to establish free states, raising major questions for the majority of states that were not then free states, fearful of Britain's military superiority and commercial power. Those who held that liberty had nothing to do with Britain's successes, but that a corrupt form of extractive commercial empire lay behind the military victories, were also innovators. Corrupt empire seemed to be a strategy for self-defeat to eighteenth-century

minds, the proof being the response of the Americans to their British masters in the 1770s, rapidly followed by the Irish and confirmed by events in India. That corrupt empire and mercantile systems could be maintained and relied upon to sustain states militarily was a new argument. The British themselves debated mercantile systems into the new century, and attempted to reform their own, in what was clearly being described as a new species of enlightenment by the time Thomas Babington Macaulay put his Whig pen to paper.

The German responses McDaniel outlines have a flavour of the previous century, reiterating tropes dating back to French propaganda of the 1750s concerning a universal empire of the seas or universal monarchy of trade. Later assertions, commonplace under the Directory or at Bonaparte's court, expressed by pro-French propagandists like Hauterive and Paine, held that Britain was seeking global dominion. Friedrich Buchholz is on solid ground then, and the arguments about the class war sound E. P. Thompsonesque. That a union of working class, peasant and middle-class would be fulfilled by Napoleon or another Caesar figure, as enunciated by Buchholz, is far from rare for these generations, as McDaniel has explained. Thompson himself would have blanched, at least after abandoning the British Communist Party in 1956 for its veneration of Stalin's action. Union by monarchy, the rule of law in a true *Rechtsstaat*, republican union or the union of all scientists by means of a new religion of humanity are all prominent in the after-enlightenment era.

But the British tend not to be seeking to plant liberty trees in other places, unlike the first French republicans. Britain's is not an empire for increase in the standard sense but for the increase of commerce, which may or may not necessitate direct political dominion. And the foreign discussants of the 'condition of England question', which means the state of every branch of the empire, matter. Karl von Rotteck's scepticism about parliamentary government and Friedrich List's about free trade were equally channelling eighteenth-century British arguments about the dire condition of their own polity. One of the greatest difficulties for those experiencing the transition period from the eighteenth to the nineteenth century was the fact that Britain should have collapsed, according to eighteenth-century logic, but had not done so. One of the most common responses was that it was coming, a view expressed by David Ricardo, Jeremy Bentham and Jean-Baptiste Say among others in the 1810s. Britain could not be trusted to remain a stable polity without suffering civil war, bankruptcy, defeat internationally or commercial decline.

That a truly free state might be the product of a revolution in law by international treaties and domestic reform was argued by the members of The Holy Alliance. Such was the faith in the Russian Tsar Alexander II, as the Napoleonic Wars ended, that the term liberalism was widely associated with his actions to create a new and more pacific world order, as Isaac Nakhimovsky has shown in his recent book on the subject.¹⁵ The world really had changed. As time passed, more and more states sought to become free states. And there did not seem to be a socialist alternative during these decades, just a revolutionary alternative, one that kept on repeating the mistakes of the past.

Many of the revolutionaries of 1848 wanted to disaggregate the French Revolution into positive and negative elements, as Conor Bollins suggests, and relived its history while failing afresh. Hegel's verdict was surely right, that the overthrow of social structures, institutions and cultures had unleashed fanaticism, such that doing the same in the present would lead to similar outcomes. István Hont argued towards the end of his life that two pet notions about the eighteenth century needed to be abandoned. The first was that there was a developing rationalism, whereas in fact what he termed a 'sophisticated sentimentalism' predominated. This led to most contemporaries being 'deeply pessimist about western societies' capacity to sustain themselves in certain conditions of globalisation and internal domestic economic competition.' The second was that the French Revolution was successful, or partially successful, which amounted to madness according to Hont:

... we are much better off if we think that the French Revolution was a terrible event but one of the most predictable events of mankind's history and one can show that it was very widely predicted almost precisely as it happened and it must not govern our understanding of how we think about nineteenth, twentieth and twenty-first century political thought.¹⁶

Revolutions, for Hont, never built consensus but rather shattered every form of social union. As such, they failed the test of modern politics, which was how to create a minimal sociability compatible with a thriving commercial society and international peace, using the powers of the state.

VII

Against Jo Innes I am going to stand by my use of the term mercantile system. The term was widely used by Smith's many readers, enunciating his attack, they recognised, upon the British Empire. Assaults upon Old Corruption generalised Smith's argument and explain why contemporaries such as Paine thought Smith was an inspiration and covert supporter of their own radicalisms. Shelburne, whose brother was educated in Smith's house, felt the same. Smith's politics, of course, were nuanced and complex, but the general view that Britain was on the verge of collapse because of a combination of mutually reinforcing corruption in politics and the economy merits emphasis. Few people were optimistic about the future of Britain in consequence at the end of enlightenment. The next generation was different, after the military victories and the debt crises, and again the term facilitates drawing a sharp distinction between the centuries.

Turning to the republics, they were not 'answers to the problem of overcoming wars of religion' in any century. My argument was not clear enough. The republics were, as Innes says, vehicles of religious bellicosity precisely because the creation of a republic replicated the process of creating a fanatic church. And as each republic died, as they all did (except San Marino) at the end of enlightenment, it marked a further change in the world, the movement from a world of small states, where republics of 25,000 persons might be safe, to a world of large states seeking markets. That Britain proved the most adept at navigating the jealousy of trade was a shock to everyone. Old republics failed. There was no republican revival. New forms of state were created, more nationalistic, commercial and geared to war and the pursuit of trade. The halcyon days of Pocock's Utrecht enlightenment, sustained by historiographies of 'the enlightened narrative', were no more.¹⁷ They did not come back. Whig History was different.

I will quickly deal with the point made by Bowman and de Felipe that I've neglected aesthetics in general and Burke's *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* in particular. It is certainly the case. I'm not sure, however, precisely what the politics are that are missed. They may be right that greater engagement with aesthetics would have facilitated richer portraits of the times, although I also think that the 'intellectual and political spheres' encompass aesthetics, because they encompass everything.

And finally to gender. The point that I want to make is that Wollstonecraft's acceptance that an attempt to establish gender equality had failed with parlous consequences, being associated for future generations with Terror and the rise of a modern Caesar, merits scrutiny. Ahistorical approaches praising Wollstonecraft for her gender politics are not enough. You can learn far more from failure. She was aware of the extent of the tragedy. And the biographical details are significant because she lived her ideas. What Wollstonecraft meant by gender equality is also worth study, because I see far less continuity, especially with contemporary perspectives. Bowman and de Felipe are right to say that gender relations are one of the keys to end of enlightenment, and that a lot more could have been said. Once more I am grateful to all these generous scholars who have taken time to engage with *The End of Enlightenment*.

Notes

1. Pocock, *Barbarism and Religion Volume I. The Enlightenments of Edward Gibbon* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 132–3; *Barbarism and Religion Volume II: Narratives of Civil Government*, 304–5; *Barbarism and Religion Volume V: Religion: The First Triumph* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 386; *Barbarism and Religion Volume VI. Barbarism: Triumph in the West* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 1–9.

2. Michael Sonenscher, *Capitalism. The Story Behind the Word* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2022). See also *After Kant. The Germans, the Romans and the Moderns in the History of Political Thought* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2023).
3. On Hobbes and after see Paul Sagar, *The Opinion of Mankind: Sociability and the Theory of the State from Hobbes to Smith* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2018).
4. On such views see Béla Kapossy, *Iselin Contra Rousseau: Sociable Patriotism and the History of Mankind* (Basel: Schwabe Verlag, 2006).
5. See further the introduction to Béla Kapossy, Isaac Nakhimovsky, Sophus Reinert and Richard Whatmore, eds., *Markets, Morals and Politics. Jealousy of Trade and the History of Political Thought* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018); Lasse S. Andersen, 'Hont and Koselleck on the Crisis of Authority', *Journal of the Philosophy of History* 17, no. 3 (2023): 357–79 and Lasse S. Andersen, 'Introduction' to István Hont, *Culture, Needs and Property Rights. Political Economy from Pufendorf to Marx* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, forthcoming).
6. Istvan Hont, 'Unsocial Sociability and the 18th Century Discourse of Politics and Society: Natural Law, Political Economy and Histories of Mankind' (paper presented for workshop at Max Planck Institute for History, Gottingen, June 26–30, 1989). This will soon be published in Andersen, ed., *Culture, Needs and Property Rights*.
7. Hont called Pufendorf an 'old' socialist (society-ist). On what he meant see Lasse S. Andersen, 'Introduction', *Culture, Needs and Property Rights*.
8. Richard Bourke, *Hegel's World Revolutions* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2023).
9. I owe this reference with thanks to Lasse S. Andersen.
10. Hont, 'Socialist Natural Law, Commercial Society, Political Economy: A Contribution to the Understanding of the Idea of Social Science' (1990) in L. S. Andersen, ed., *Culture, Needs and Property Rights*.
11. For the Maoist strategy with regard to peasants in India see M. Basavapunnaiah, 'The "Statement of Policy" Reviewed' (Reprinted from the Marxist, Vol. III, No. 3–4), April 1986, [https://www.marxists.org/subject/india/cpi\(m\)/statement-policy-review.pdf](https://www.marxists.org/subject/india/cpi(m)/statement-policy-review.pdf). In Cuba see Gil Carl AlRoy, 'The Peasantry in the Cuban Revolution', *The Review of Politics* 29, no. 1 (1967): 87–99. In Zimbabwe see Fay Chung, *Re-Living the Second Chimurenga. Memories from the Liberation Struggle in Zimbabwe, with an Introduction by Preben Kaarsholm* (Stockholm: Nordic Africa Institute, Weaver Press, 2006), 78. See also Julia Lovell, *Maoism. A Global History* (London and New York: Bodley Head, 2019).
12. Ashton Robinson, 'Zimbabwe: New Crocodile, Same Teeth', *The Interpreter*, November 20, 2017, <https://www.lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/zimbabwe-new-crocodile-same-teeth>.
13. See further Quentin Skinner, *Hobbes and Republican Liberty* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008).
14. David Armitage, *Civil Wars. A History in Ideas* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2017).
15. Isaac Nakhimovsky, *The Holy Alliance* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2024).
16. Hont, 'Rousseau and Smith. A Conversation with István Hont', Minda de Gunzburg Centre for European Studies, Harvard University, 2011, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v83Zh2IenM4>.
17. Pocock, *Barbarism and Religion Volume I. The Enlightenments of Edward Gibbon*, 132–3; *Barbarism and Religion Volume II: Narratives of Civil Government*, 304–5; *Barbarism and Religion Volume V: Religion: The First Triumph*, 386; *Barbarism and Religion Volume VI. Barbarism: Triumph in the West*, 1–9.

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